

PRABHAKAR TIWARI/AI

A TIERED TIRAMISU OR A DOUBLE-PATTY CHICKEN BURGER–JUST A GLANCE CAN SET OFF CRAVINGS. That's no accident. Our brains are hardwired to seek sugar and salt, a relic of our hunter-gatherer past when such indulgences were rare but vital for survival.

But today, ultra-processed foods dominate our diets. Known as HFSS (high in fat, salt and sugar) foods—or simply junk food—they are factory-made, energy-dense and packed with additives like preservatives, sweeteners and emulsifiers—ingredients you don't typically find in home kitchens. They commonly masquerade as chocolates, sugary treats, salty snacks, beverages, ready-to-cook and ready-to-eat meals, instant noodles and ice cream. Once occasional treats, their easy reach—on kitchen shelves or through delivery apps—have turned them into a daily habit, and a dangerously addictive one. So much so that the Supreme Court, hearing a public interest litigation on April 9, gave the Centre a three-month deadline to make labelling on packaged food stronger. The move aims to raise public awareness about food intake and encourage informed choices.

The market size of ultra-processed foods—chocolate and sugar confectionery, salty snacks, ice cream, biscuits, cold beverages, processed meat, ready-made and convenience foods, and breakfast cereals—grew at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 10 per cent from 2019, reaching Rs 2.58 lakh crore in 2024. It is projected to rise to Rs 3.98 lakh crore by 2029, according to market research firm Euromonitor. In fact, the share of packaged (highly processed and calorie-dense) foods in household food budgets doubled from 6.5 per cent in 2015 to 12 per cent in 2019, with household spends on outside food increasing by 32 per cent, from Rs 61,900 crore in 2015 to Rs 82,000 crore in 2019 (Global Food Policy Report, 2024). The government's Household Consumption Expenditure Survey 2023-24 confirmed the trend: beverages, refreshments and processed food were the top food expenses in urban and rural households, a shift away from essential food items.

The rising consumption of HFSS foods is taking a significant toll on public health. A 2024 research paper published in *The BMJ* journal, which examined data from nearly 9.9 million people across multiple countries, linked 32 harmful health issues to consumption of ultra-processed food. These include a higher risk of cancer, obesity, hypertension, type 2 diabetes, mental health issues such as depression and sleep disorders, heart disease, chronic kidney disease (see *The Silent Threat*), leading to early death. Within the country, as research published in the journal *PLOS One* in June 2024 highlighted, the burden of lifestyle diseases has tripled since 1995, growing at a much faster rate than communicable diseases.

It's no surprise, then, that a major study—backed by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) and the Union health ministry, and published in *The Lancet* in July 2023—found that 101 million Indians, or 11.4 per cent of the population, have diabetes. What is more concerning is that 15.3 per cent (136 million people) have prediabetes, 28.6 per cent suffer from obesity and 35.5 per cent have hypertension—all linked to rising junk food consumption. "The alarming rise in lifestyle diseases is largely driven by poor dietary habits," says Dr R.M. Anjana, managing director of Chennai-based Dr Mohan's Diabetes Specialities Centre and lead author of the ICMR research. "The increased consumption of ultra-processed foods, which are high in calories but poor in nutrients, is leading to an obesity epidemic, which in turn becomes the causal pathway to several other metabolic disorders," she says. The situation is worse among children. While sedentary lifestyle and stress also contribute to lifestyle diseases